

## **Cultural Citizenship: Rights to Be Different and to Belong to**

Have you ever felt like you belonged to a place and didn't belong at the same time? For many people, especially religious and ethnic minorities, this is a daily reality. This goes beyond borders or legal documents. It's about being a citizen of a nation yet feeling out of place, like your culture, religion or way of life does not fully fit in or is ignored. These experiences are addressed by the idea of cultural citizenship. Cultural Citizenship is about being able to express one's culture and traditions freely, and being fully accepted by the society for who you are. As cultural anthropologist Renato Rosaldo (1994) describes, cultural citizenship is "the right to be different and to belong in a participatory democratic sense" (p. 402). In other words, it is not about just carrying a passport, but about being able to live one's identity openly, with respect and recognition.

In today's increasingly globalized world, theories of cultural identity and belonging helps us to explain how cultural identity and citizenship intersect. Appiah (2006) challenges the notion of cultural purity and refers to "contamination" (p. 7) as a positive form of connection, where identities are evolved through ongoing cultural interactions and exchange. He expresses how cultures have always changed and embracing such exchange supports mutual understanding in a globalized world. Similarly, Sen (2006) argues that identity is not inherited or singular but plural. According to him, identities can be chosen depending on context, priorities and reasoning as individuals simultaneously belong to many different groups, such as, nationality, language and religion. Stuart Hall (1990) expands this further by emphasizing that cultural identity is a matter of both "being" and "becoming"(p. 225). Cultural identity, he says, is not fixed or inherited once and for all; it is constructed over time, through rupture, history and migration. This perspective of his made space for hybrid, diasporic, and evolving identities. Together, these views expand the idea of citizenship; one that includes not just legal status, but cultural, emotional, and symbolic dimensions of belonging.

These ideas come to life in the lived experiences of people who find themselves at the intersection of different cultural and religious identities. In Bangladesh, where the majority of the population is Muslim, a Hindu student from Dhaka shared how Durga Puja is one of the most important festivals in her community. This five-day vibrant event is a joyous religious and cultural festival that brings communities together. Families in the neighborhood contribute to organizing a shared puja, offering prasad, and buying new clothes to mark the celebration. Yet, challenges often emerge when seeking permission to hold the puja in public spaces. Occasionally, permission to hold puja has been denied, stating that it will cause disruption to other religious practices. Even more difficult is the overlap between the Hindu evening Aarti, prayer involving instruments such as 'ghanta' (bells) and 'dhol' (drums) and the Muslim call to prayer, Azan. She explained that they are asked not to use musical instruments during that time

to avoid interference. Though these requests are respected, it feels one-sided. Although not constant, these moments reflect how cultural citizenship isn't always equal and minorities sometimes need to adjust for coexistence.

This experience reflects Amartya Sen's (2006) argument that identity is not singular or reducible to one aspect. The student is both Bangladeshi and Hindu, yet the public perception sometimes treats these identities as incompatible. At the same time, her participation in Durga Puja despite such barriers also supports Appiah's vision of culture as something continuously evolving through interaction and lived practices.

A clear example of diasporic hybridity is seen in a student whose parents are Bengali Muslims from Chittagong, but she was born in Spain and moved to the United Kingdom when she was seven. Now fifteen, she identifies more with British culture than with Bangladesh or Spain. She speaks some Bangla at home, eats Bangladeshi food occasionally, and follows traditions like Eid yet feels most at ease in the UK. She admits that when visiting Bangladesh, she felt welcomed and was surrounded by familiar relatives and recognized many cultural elements. However, she found the food culture somewhat unfamiliar, particularly the routine of eating rice twice a day, which differs from her usual meals in the UK. The food also felt too spicy at times, and the hot, humid climate made the experience more uncomfortable. These differences made her appreciate the comfort and cultural familiarity of her life in Britain even more.

Her experience represents both hybridity and diaspora. Rather than abandoning her heritage, she has formed a hybrid identity by integrating elements of Bangladeshi culture with her British upbringing. This mirrors Appiah's (2006, p. 7) concept of culture "contamination", where cultural exchange is seen as enriching rather than threatening. It also aligns with Hall's (1990, p. 226) argument that cultural identity is not fixed but constantly shaped through experience, movement, and memory. This reflects her evolving "diasporic identity", that is not only Bangladeshi or only British, but a combination of both, which shows the plurality of her identity.

Another example comes from a Bangladeshi student who recently visited Malaysia on vacation. There, she sensed that locals could tell she was a foreigner based on skin tone. At the same time, she felt a sense of familiarity when she noticed many Malaysian women wearing hijabs, just like her mother. Despite being in a different country, she felt welcomed and supported by the kindness of strangers.

This brief encounter supports Hall's (1990) view that identity is formed not just through sameness, but also through recognition and lived experience. Identity is not fixed, but continually "becoming" through interactions with both difference and familiarity. Here, the presence of a familiar religious symbol in an unfamiliar environment created a momentary feeling of belonging. Likewise, Amartya Sen's (2006) concept of plural and contextual identity also

applies here, as the student reflects multiple identities, like being Bangladeshi, Muslim and tourist all at once. Her experience reveals how cultural citizenship can momentarily form even outside one's nation-state.

These stories show that cultural citizenship is not only about how others see us, it is also about how we choose to see ourselves. Even in moments of silence or compromise, like when the student was asked to stop using musical instruments during Aarti, there are individuals actively negotiating their place in society without erasing their cultural identity. Cultural citizenship, therefore, is expressed through everyday practices: language, clothing, festival, and food across generations and borders. For minorities and those straddling multiple cultures, belonging is not something given, but something continuously earned. Cultural citizenship insists that people should not have to trade parts of themselves to be accepted. It pushes us to rethink who counts as a citizen, not just in legal terms, but in cultural terms too. Ultimately, it reminds us that true democracy embraces diversity as a strength, not as a threat.

## References:

Appiah, K. A. (2006, January 1). *The case for contamination*. The New York Times.

<https://www.nytimes.com/2006/01/01/magazine/the-case-for-contamination.html>

Hall, S. (1990). Cultural identity and diaspora. In J. Rutherford (Ed.), *Identity: Community, Culture, Difference*, (pp. 222–237). Lawrence & Wishart.

Rosaldo, R. (1994). Cultural Citizenship and Educational Democracy. *Cultural Anthropology*, 9(3), 402–411.

<http://www.jstor.org/stable/656372>

Sen, A. (2006). *Identity and Violence: The Illusion of Destiny*. W. W. Norton & Company.